

Teaching Statement

1 Teaching Philosophy

My idea of what the goals of teaching should be can be compared to the role members of most species, except perhaps humans, play in the development of their offspring — they provide the newborn with the minimum that is necessary for its survival, allow it to practice survival under a very brief tutelage, and then leave it to manage entirely on its own. My general approach to teaching a topic is to get students interested in it and to equip them with the technical know-how, if any, required for independent exploration.

My two main goals when teaching linguistics are to get students to think scientifically about language, and to provide them with the tools to apply this knowledge in and outside academia (industry or their community work). I also insist on teaching students traditional (questionnaire-based) and non-traditional (experiment-based) language data collection techniques to ensure that students engage critically with linguistic theory, while also learning skills crucial for non-academic jobs. Linguistics is highly interdisciplinary and I ensure that my teaching reflects this so that a student interested and skilled in one or more disciplines that linguistics intersects with — literature, sociology, politics, education, psychology, neurology, computer science — sees the breadth and reach of studying language.

I believe that classrooms must include rather than exclude. I therefore keep my teaching style accessible, my teaching material lucid, and my evaluation dynamic. I ensure that I am approachable and available to answer students' questions and discuss assigned and other readings. To include more students in the teaching-learning process I do not compromise on the natural difficulty level of a course. However, I ensure that I design my courses to cater to the needs and goals of my classroom. Therefore, for instance, an *Introduction to Linguistics* course I would design for students of a bachelor's in Linguistics would be different from one I would design for students pursuing a bachelor's in English. For the former, I would teach the core areas of linguistics using cross-linguistic data, with the applied areas I discuss including language acquisition, the human brain and language, and language endangerment, among others. In the latter, I would teach students about contemporary English grammar, including that of the various varieties of English (Indian, African-American, Irish, Singaporean, and Australian), many of which have a significant presence in English literature. As an introduction to the applied areas of linguistics, I would teach them English lexicology and lexicography, the history of the English language, English language variation and change, and language policy and planning, since all of these impacts the literature produced across the world.

2 Teaching experience and methods

The paradox of teaching linguistics is that while the discipline concerns itself with an endowment available to every human, it can often be exclusionary. In countries like India, where classrooms are linguistically diverse, the discipline, especially formal linguistics, is often alienating for new students because they cannot relate to textbook examples, which are primarily from languages like English, which they have no grammaticality judgments on. I am thus trained to teach linguistics using data from languages spoken by the diverse group of students in my classes, as would also be the case in IIT Bombay's classrooms. For example, if I were teaching free word order in my classroom, my examples of the phenomenon would not be from German, Japanese, or Turkish, but from South Asian languages so that students who speak these languages can enrich the discussion of the topic in the classroom.

I have taught both introductory as well as intermediate-level linguistics courses. In introductory courses in linguistics, I teach students the fundamental content areas of linguistics to establish a solid foundation and improve their confidence. For instance, in the undergraduate course *Introduction to Linguistics* for foreign language students at Jawaharlal Nehru University, I co-designed the course to first have students see how language is special to humans, and familiarise them with the defining features of human language and the levels language divides itself up into. The first module *Language the most human thing about us* was used to get students interested in Linguistics. Students were then introduced to the core areas of study in linguistics via short modules on them. This exploration was done via ample examples from natural language, and students were encouraged to think about the sounds, words, and sentence structures of their languages and the foreign languages they were studying. They were then taught modules on a few applied areas of linguistics to introduce the empirical side of the discipline.

In intermediate courses, I teach the concepts and methods necessary to start a specialisation area, by analysing linguistic data and reading relevant literature. I engage students with seminal texts and (critically) test these theories in empirical waters. I did this in the master's level course *Phonology*. For example, in the *Generative phonology* module of the course, I first explained what generative phonology is, including

how it is part of Generative approaches to grammar and what its goals are. I thereafter taught students the prerequisites of the generative phonology machinery including its assumptions regarding levels of representation and the elsewhere principle. I then taught them the ins and outs of phonological rule formalism using cross-linguistic data. We practiced rule-writing for cross-linguistic data sets in the classroom after which students were assigned practice problem sets as homework. Many problem sets were from the languages of India that they were familiar with. For every module, I provided students with a list of seminal works, textbooks, and resources from which certain pages were assigned as obligatory readings.

Although I have not taught Advanced-level courses yet, I would like to reserve these for critically reading and discussing seminal and advanced-level works, writing article reviews and book reviews, conducting novel empirical research, and writing it up as an academic paper or dissertation. The aim here would be to teach students fine scientific argumentation by studying a very specific linguistic phenomenon and looking at how this connects to big-picture questions in linguistics and allied disciplines.

Teaching also happens outside the classroom, and one of my favorite ways of teaching is through advising. I encourage students to discuss their work in progress, and we try to solve problems that do not necessarily have simple answers. My experience of teaching at public universities in India during the pandemic taught me to provide my students with alternatives to books and academic papers since unequipped with laptops, they could not read these comfortably on their phones. I, therefore, converted the most relevant literature into slides and provided alternative teaching-learning material (video lectures, blog posts, podcasts) available on the internet. My course-outlines and teaching handouts/slides can be provided upon request.

I believe that evaluation must aim to test students' level of understanding of a topic, and their ability to engage critically with it and think of its empirical coverage, rather than aiming to test for textbook-style definitions of jargon. For instance, if I wanted to test if students know the phenomenon of language endangerment, I would ask them the following question: *Languages are born and die like living beings do. What causes languages to journey towards death? Are there stages in this journey? Discuss this with an example or two of real or hypothetical languages that are dying.* I would not ask *Define language endangerment.*

Every student has their strengths and weaknesses. Some can design and execute experiments well, while some are good at data analysis and statistics. Others' strengths lie in arguing succinctly in words. I, therefore, encourage evaluation methods such as group designing and execution of fieldwork questionnaires or a language experiment, group term papers, and presentations. Working in groups initiates students into the world of collaborative research and work, something that is valuable both in and outside academia. My individual-based evaluation methods include sit-down closed-book exams, sit-down open-book exams, 24-hour take-home exams, and writing term papers, article reviews, and book reviews. I often use cross-linguistic data sets and ask students to reflect on their own language(s) in my questions.